

Diplomatic Freezer

Four meetings and two years after, the much-hyped Indo-Pak initiative to combat terrorism has no results to speak of

The more things change, the more they remain the same. That has been the story of the India-Pakistan equation and remains so till now, despite a change of government in Islamabad and the backslapping encounter Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had with President Asif Zardari at New York, and more recently, with Prime Minister Yusuf Raza Gilani at the Asia-Europe summit in Beijing. The most illustrative example of the so-called "trust deficit" which continues to keep Indo-Pak relations in cold storage is the Joint Anti Terror Mechanism (JATM), that has stymied India's battle against Pakistan-sponsored terrorism. At every meeting of the JATM, New Delhi's efforts to corner Pakistan on terror issues, now focussed on July's suicide blast in the Indian Embassy in Kabul, have resulted in the all-too-familiar stonewalling or outright denial, rendering the mechanism a non-starter. It was decided at the Manmohan-Zardari meeting that a special JATM session be convened to discuss the Kabul blast.

The group, headed by two additional secretaries from the respective foreign ministries, met in Delhi last week to take stock of the investigations into the Kabul blast, where the Pakistani side demanded further proof as a delaying tactic while India has already given adequate evidence, clearly pointing out the involvement of Mullah Abdur Rahman Zahid, former deputy foreign minister of the Taliban regime, as the mastermind of the attack at the behest of the Pakistan's intelligence agency. Zahid, India pointed out, now resides in Peshawar. It cut little ice with the Pakistani delegation, as did the fresh list of fugitives wanted in India, headed by underworld don Dawood Ibrahim and his aide Karimullah Hussain Khan, who is believed to be in Karachi, besides LeT operatives Mohammed Imran Batt and Raziuddin Nasir, accused of bomb blasts in India. The Indian side even produced photographs of Jaish-e-

Mohammed chief Maulana Masood Azhar, another key fugitive, supervising the building of a new house in Peshawar, but Pakistan's response was that "he is a fugitive that we are also looking for". Also, they accused India of fomenting tensions in Baluchistan. "It is a tactical move by Pakistan to ease the pressure on the terror issue. We are just

Afghan Government have confirmed Pakistan's hand, what is the point of meeting when no action has been taken against the conspirators," says K.C. Singh, former head of the JATM.

When the mechanism was set up, tall claims were made that it will help India corner Pakistan on the issue of terrorism, but more than two years have passed and scores of innocents have died in various bomb blasts in India but the mechanism has not worked. It has, instead, brought the perpetrator of terrorism, Pakistan, on the same platform as India, which is a victim of terrorism. For all its good intentions, the JATM has become a con-

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NON-STARTER

- The mechanism was set up in 2006 to deal with issues related to terrorism and to exchange specific information on the terror attacks but continues to be a non-starter.
- At a special meet of the Indo-Pak joint terror mechanism, India's attempts to seek action against the Kabul blast conspirators were stonewalled by Pakistan.
- The JATM is only a scaled-down reflection of the existing interaction between home secretaries on terror issues.
- The great fanfare with which India launched the mechanism has become its undoing: its failure cannot be acknowledged, and it can't be dumped.

PLASTIC SMILES: Manmohan Singh and Zardari meet in New York

wasting our time, it was never going to work," says an official frustrated by the deliberations of the JATM.

In fact seasoned diplomats questioned the need of a special meeting of the mechanism on the Kabul blast. "Post-Kabul, when even the US and

venient fig leaf for Islamabad to stonewall and employ delaying tactics while showing the world that it is cooperating with India in the war against terror. Having launched the mechanism with great fanfare, South Block can hardly admit that it is a failure. Diplomatically, the UPA Government has been hoist with its own petard.

by Saurabh Shukla